



Flawless performance: KKR registered a clinical win in the final after its bowlers restricted SRH's strong batting line-up to a below-par score. This is the former's third IPL title. K. R. DEEPAK

that of riding out the initial phase in swing-friendly conditions.

But for a leader who had seen his team start off like the clappers, rewrite batting records, spawn conversations about what wretched fate awaited bowlers, and succeed in high-risk methods, there was no turning back. It was boom or bust, and the latter would eventually run its course.

But to dilate on the league's most expensive players would be reductionist. Though Starc found his stride late in the tournament and peaked in the playoffs, it was the



Knight Riders' Indian bowling group — Harshit Rana, Vaibhav Arora, and Varun Chakravarthy — that was pivotal in its dominant run.

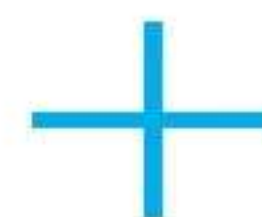
In the final, Arora accounted for Travis Head in the PowerPlay, Rana served a masterclass in deception in the middle overs by nabbing Nitish Kumar Reddy and Heinrich Klaasen, and Chakravarthy was at his economical best.

The three had their roles perfectly assigned. In the Knight Riders' campaign opener, also against SRH, Rana proved his credentials as someone who could deliver under

Roar of a champion: Mitchell Starc (left) was merciless with the ball, picking up two wickets for just 14 runs in three overs. He was adjudged Man of the Match. R. RAGU

pressure when he defended 12 runs against a high-flying Klaasen breathing down his neck.

Arora, introduced later in the tournament, was a revelation with his ability to get breakthroughs with the new ball — nine of his 11 wickets this season came in the PowerPlay. This allowed Rana to shift focus to the middle overs when his variations



Though not many fancied KKR's chances, it had all its bases covered, largely thanks to an unfancied Indian core and an in-form overseas unit.